Xinyu (Leona) Guan

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Educational Leadership and Policy Analysis (Policy Evaluation Track) Expected Spring 2027
University of Wisconsin–Madison
Dissertation: *Aligning Resources with Need: Staffing, School Finance, and Bilingual-Bicultural Aid for English Learners in Wisconsin*
Advisor: Christopher M. Saldaña · Committee: Francesca López, Mollie McQuillan, Richard Halverson

Ph.D. Minor, Quantitative Research Methods, Department of Educational Psychology Completed
University of Wisconsin–Madison · Minor advisor: Jee-Seon Kim

M.A., Educational Leadership and Policy Analysis (Concentration: Global Higher Education) 2022
University of Wisconsin–Madison

B.A., Finance and Economics 2015
McMaster University, Hamilton, ON

RESEARCH INTERESTS

K–12 school finance and resource equity; English learner and multilingual learner policy; teacher labor markets and staffing; quasi-experimental methods with state administrative data.

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

State School Finance Fellow, EdFund (12 selected from 125+ applicants) 2026–2027
Barbara L. Jackson Scholar, University Council for Educational Administration (UCEA) 2024–2026
Graduate Student Travel Grant, School of Education, UW–Madison 2026
Henry Ahrnsbrak Student Support Scholarship, Educational Leadership and Policy Analysis 2024, 2025
Roe L. Johns Student Travel Grant, Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP) 2024
Russell T. Gregg Memorial Scholarship, Educational Leadership and Policy Analysis 2022

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Guan, X. (2025). Delaware state of the states report, 2024–2025. *Journal of Education Human Resources*.

Saldaña, C. M., & **Guan, X.** (2025). Examining trends and patterns in K–12 school security expenditures in Texas. *Texas Education Review*.

Molle, D., Liou, Y.-H., Childs, J., Saldaña, C. M., Clifford, M., Awaludin, A., **Guan, X.**, Halverson, R., & Lee, Y. (2025). Exploring the evolution of district–university partnerships focused on equity-centered leadership. *Journal of Professional Capital and Community*.

BOOK CHAPTERS

Molle, D., Liou, Y.-H., **Guan, X.**, Halverson, R., Saldaña, C. M., & Childs, J. (2025). Networks that learn: Leveraging social network analysis for system-level learning and equity-focused change. In *International handbook of school effectiveness and improvement* (2nd ed.).

REPORTS

Molle, D., Halverson, R., Probst, C., Liou, Y.-H., Mosby, J., Acosta, J., & **Guan, X.** (2026). *The role of partnerships in supporting equity-centered school leadership: Lessons from intensive work in 8 urban school districts*. CALL-ECL; The Wallace Foundation. https://doi.org/10.59656/EL-LS5116.001

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW AND IN PREPARATION

Guan, X., & López, F. Leadership support for multilingual learners' opportunity to learn. Under review, *Teachers College Record*.

Guan, X., & Saldaña, C. M. Examining the distribution of K–12 bilingual and bicultural aid in Wisconsin. Target: *Educational Policy*.

Guan, X. Where are English learners in Wisconsin, and do schools have the staff to serve them? Dissertation paper 1, in preparation.

Guan, X. Funding that doesn't follow: Structural versus responsive progressivity for English learners in Wisconsin school finance. Dissertation paper 2, in preparation.

Guan, X. Funding English learners with a single stream: A critical policy analysis of Wisconsin. Dissertation paper 3, in preparation.

Guan, X., & Halverson, R. Determining key factors in the racial makeup of new teacher hires: An interpretable machine learning analysis. In preparation. Target: *AERA Open*.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Molle, D., Liou, Y.-H., **Guan, X.**, McCormick, M. A., Childs, J., & Saldaña, C. M. (2027). Professional networks as sources of support for educational leaders engaged in equity-centered work. International Congress for School Effectiveness and Improvement (ICSEI). Accepted.

Guan, X. (2026). Centering equity for multilingual English learners: A multi-measure school finance analysis in Wisconsin. AERA Annual Meeting.

Guan, X. (2025). A three-paper analysis of bilingual education funding equity in Wisconsin. UCEA Annual Convention, Puerto Rico.

Guan, X. (2025). Early access, mixed outcomes: Estimating the effect of bilingual program eligibility on elementary achievement in Wisconsin. AERA Annual Meeting, Denver, CO.

Guan, X., Saldaña, C. M., & Romero, M. (2025). A critical policy analysis of K–12 bilingual education finance policy in Wisconsin. AERA Annual Meeting, Denver, CO.

Guan, X., Davalos, L., & Saldaña, C. M. (2025). Building FAIR school finance data systems: A multi-state and federal analysis. AEFP Annual Conference, Washington, DC.

Saldaña, C. M., Liou, Y.-H., Molle, D., **Guan, X.**, et al. (2025). Examining school district costs associated with designing, implementing, and operating equity-centered school leadership systems. AERA Annual Meeting, Denver, CO.

Guan, X., & Saldaña, C. M. (2024). Examining trends and patterns in K–12 school security expenditures in Texas. UCEA Annual Convention, Los Angeles, CA.

Guan, X., & Saldaña, C. M. (2024). Equity in action: Redesigning funding models for English learners in Wisconsin. UCEA Annual Convention, Los Angeles, CA.

Guan, X., & Saldaña, C. M. (2024). Tracking trends, patterns, and variation in K–12 school security spending in Texas [Poster]. AEFP Annual Conference, Baltimore, MD.

Guan, X., Awaludin, A., & Halverson, R. R. (2024). Exploring partnership evolution in support of systems change toward equity-centered leadership: A mixed-methods social network analysis [Poster]. AERA Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

Liou, Y.-H., Saldaña, C. M., Clifford, M. A., Awaludin, A., **Guan, X.**, et al. (2024). Collaborating to support equity-centered leadership: A two-year social network analysis of eight districts. AERA Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA.

Clifford, M. A., Molle, D., Halverson, R. R., Kallio, J. M., Saldaña, C. M., Awaludin, A., Childs, J., & **Guan, X.** (2023). Preparing for innovation: Mapping districts' initial efforts to build partnerships around equity-centered principal pipelines. AERA Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Project Assistant, Wisconsin Center for Education Research, UW–Madison Sept 2025–Present

CALL Opportunities to Learn (CALL-OTL), funded by the Wallace Foundation

- Lead validation of survey instruments using exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis and Rasch analysis.
- Build reproducible R and Stata workflows with Git version control; translate psychometric findings for district and school partners.

Research Assistant, Wisconsin Center for Education Research, UW–Madison 2022–Aug 2025

CALL/Equity-Centered Leadership and CALL/Mapping Equity Indicators, funded by the Wallace Foundation

- Linked federal and state achievement, demographic, and finance data to build equity indicators aligned with the NASEM framework.
- Built interactive data tools for district and school leaders; conducted social network analysis of multi-district survey data.
- Co-authored a Wallace Foundation technical report on equity-centered leader pathways (2024).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Graduate Teaching Assistant, University of Wisconsin–Madison 2023–2025

- Designed and facilitated a hands-on data science workshop for the Wisconsin Idea Executive Ph.D. cohort of mid-career education practitioners.

Cambridge Certified Teacher (TESOL), New Oriental Education & Technology Group, China 2017–2019

- Taught English to diverse learners in classroom and individual settings.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Financial Auditor, BDO China 2015–2017

- Audited and documented large-scale financial records for corporate clients in compliance with regulatory standards.

PUBLIC SCHOLARSHIP AND OPEN-SOURCE TOOLS

Bilingual Policy Tracker (leonaguan.github.io/bilingual-policy-tracker). Interactive web application comparing multilingual learner funding, policy, and legislation across all 50 states.

METHODS AND SKILLS

Methods: Difference-in-differences and event studies, regression discontinuity, panel and longitudinal models, multilevel modeling (HLM), SEM, EFA/CFA, Rasch analysis, social network analysis, interpretable machine learning, policy simulation.

Software: R (primary; ggplot2, Shiny), Stata, Python, SQL, LaTeX, Git/GitHub.

Data: Wisconsin DPI finance, staffing, and WISEdash files; School Finance Indicators Database; Census F-33 school district finance; NCES CCD and EDGE (CWIFT); California teacher and school administrative data.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE AND MEMBERSHIPS

Chinese-language editor (volunteer), *Cultural Bridges Magazine*, Cultural Bridges program, Issaquah Schools Foundation, Issaquah, WA.

Memberships: American Educational Research Association; Association for Education Finance and Policy; University Council for Educational Administration.